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Lessons from SWD work near Anna Nagar Tower Metro Station

T. SWAMINATHAN

The stormwater drain work near Anna Nagar Tower Metro Station has been under way for more than three months and is still incomplete. The prolonged construction has left portions of the area pockmarked with pits, creating a serious threat to the safety of those using the stretch every day.

The seriousness of the situation was tragically highlighted on August 23, 2026, when a woman reportedly slipped and fell into a water-filled pit at the work site and lost her life. This unfortunate incident raises serious questions about

the safety arrangements and precautions being taken at the site.

While the need for stormwater drainage infrastructure is understandable, public safety cannot be compromised during the execution of such works. Proper barricading, warning signs, adequate lighting and safe pedestrian access must be ensured throughout the construction period.

Chennai Metro Water Supply and Sewerage Board and the other departments must inspect the site and ensure all safety measures are in place and expedite the pending work.

T. Swaminathan is a resident of Valayapathi Salai, Mogappair East



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View of the road.



Obstruction on Anna Nagar West 17th Main Road

PRAMODE ALEX

With the closure of a part of 100 Feet Road near Thirumangalam Junction (Anna Nagar West), there has been diversion of the Padi-to-Koyambedu traffic into the rightward road such as 18th Main Road and 17th Main Road.

The end of 17th Main Road has several garbage bins and overflowing garbage from the bins blocks a large portion of the road.

This is also one of the exit points for large machinery and trucks for CMRL work at Thirumangalam.

This poses a serious threat to motorists as they turn right into 17th Main Road.

'Patchwork' on Loco bridge has unravelled

ANOSH NISHTER SADAT

The Loco bridge or the twin bridge is one of the oldest bridges in north Chennai, connecting ICF, Ayanavaram, Anna Nagar, Villivakkam, New Avadi road and Arumbakkam. The bridge needs a cement road or a bitumen road, especially the section of the bridge that is used by the public coming from Anna Nagar and Ayanavaram and heading towards the Loco railway station entrance. On the evening of August 24 some patchwork was carried out on this bridge, which lands you towards GKM Colony or the entrance of Loco railway station, but the very next day after a brief shower all the bitumen put in as part of the patchwork unravelled. As a number of motorists use this bridge, robust re-laying work is required.

Anosh Nishter Sadat is a resident of SRP Koil Street (North), Thiruvika Nagar, Perambur



Images of the pothole-ridden stretch and (above) after the patchwork.

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NATURALISED IN MADRAS

Ato is a gift Indians repatriated from Burma gave to Madras, their new home. And by owning and relishing this dish, Madras gave them a sense of connection **P2**



PARK YOUR CAR OVER YOUR OPEN WELL

With the right design, an open well need not be a space taker; it can instead offer space for parking or anything else in addition to providing water-related benefits **P4**



Bricklin Road thrown out of kilter

Residents note that slow-moving stormwater drain work is proving a challenge to those navigating the road by wheels or by foot

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

A couple of days ago, Lakshmanswamy, a resident of a gated community on Bricklin Road received a sage counsel from a cab driver and he has committed that advice to heart. Lakshmanswamy had booked the cab from Ambattur and at the entrance of Bricklin Road, the vehicle was stuck and would not enter it as if an invisible but heavy-duty iron barrier had come up before it. Lakshmanswamy recalls how a stubborn logjam in Bricklin Road had kept vehicles rooted where they were, and after waiting for what seemed an eternity to him, the driver threw up his hands in despair, “You walk the distance to your home, you will make it faster by foot than by wheels.”

And then came that “counsel for the road”. Always book your cab up to this point, never to any location on that road. Lakshman-



PHOTOS: PRINCE FREDERICK

swamy does not think the cab driver was being rude, just offering kindly advice.

Residents of Bricklin Road have been suffering to cover the home stretch due to a stormwater drain

work that has shrunk the road, and is horrifically slow-moving, and causing traffic logjams. Residents of two gated communities, Lumbini Square and Arihant Vaidyanth, have been diligently purs-

ing the matter, taking it step by step with GCC officials, escalating it every time one step proves unhelpful.

“From the AE to the deputy commissioner, we have raised the issue with the officials, but the status quo continues,” notes Sanjay Bhansali, another resident. “Recently, residents of a slum located off Bricklin Road (called Thideer Nagar) launched a protest, seeking speedy completion of the stormwa-

ter drain.

Karthik, another resident, notes that on Bricklin Road, encroachments by commercial establishments ought to be addressed as well. He expressed a sense of dread at the thought of what could happen to Bricklin Road if a SPR City in Perambur became fully functional; at present, it is operating only at 70 percent of its capacity, Karthik noted. “Bricklin Road is a straight road to SPR City and therefore the quickest,” Karthik added. “Having this development in view, encroachments by commercial establishments on Bricklin Road have to be cleared.”

While that is a worry for another day and treated so, the one in the present needs to be addressed, which is reduced carriageway for motorists and absolute lack of walking space for pedestrians.

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Atho is a gift Indians repatriated from Burma gave to Madras, their new home. And by owning and relishing this dish, Madras gave them a sense of connection with their past, people and culture as return gift

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

People marry into money. Abdul Rahman married into "Atho". And the latter situation translates to money saved by the plates. "I have never had to pay for a plate of Atho after marriage," Rahman chuckles.

Rahman is the son-in-law of Abdul Ajeez, whose eponymous Ajeez Atho Shop at Arrababu Street off Rajaji Salai in George Town has the effect of a speed governor on an environment geared to movement and bustle. The milling crowd on Rajaji Salai contrasts with the stationary, slurping crowd around Ajeez's shop. Customers, their work bags slung over their shoulders, tuck into plates of Atho as if it were their comfort food.

Atho shops in this part of George Town present these two scenarios. Local residents "own" Atho as one would a home-grown dish, treating it as a gift from Madras; a good number of them are likely unaware of the Burma backstory. And those Indians who left Burma (now Myanmar) for Madras find that connection with the Burma of the past sustained through Atho's popularity in this city. Through it, they also enjoy a sense of community among their own. Take these illustrations.

At Arrababu Street, Ajeez Atho Shop is at a vantage point enjoying

clear visibility from Rajaji Salai but patronage does not derive entirely from that factor. Rahman observes that with Ajeez, selling Atho has never merely been a business. With parents having lived in Burma, and leaving it behind for India, specifically Madras, as repatriates following the coup d'état in 1962, Ajeez views making and selling Atho as a bridge to his culture and people. This passion runs in the family. Rahman notes that his relatives operate similar Atho stalls in Trichy and Kutralam, further reinforcing food's known status as a mark of culture and community.

Legacy food should have secret recipes. Rahman insists there is no secret recipe; the true craft lies entirely in the balance of mixing and proportion. The shop caters to every craving with its main varieties: vegetarian, fried, and egg Atho, each customised to individual spice tolerances. Crucially, vegetarian and non-vegetarian preparation areas are kept strictly separate, ensuring no one's dietary preferences are compromised.

Ajeez operates from this spot for 20 years but has been in the Atho business for twice that number of years. After 40 years, he has found allies in his sons, Haider Ali and Yusuf. "On days my father-in-law is out of station or not well, his sons take care of the stall," observes Rahman.

And Rahman points out he does not assist in the running of the shop, just content being an avid Atho taster. And also volunteering to be a spokesperson, as he did for

Naturalised in Madras



Ajeez Atho Shop at Arrababu Street; and Shahul Hameed's shop at Second Line Beach Road in George Town.

this interview. Rahman points out the stall has appeared on several media platforms and attracted many VIPs who visit the stall during the less crowded hours.

Blurring of hierarchies

Shahul Hameed is the boss, and he is aged 30. Vincent Alphonse reports to Shahul at his Atho stall on Second Line Beach Road, and is more than twice his boss' age, having been born in 1962. The usual

hierarchical boss-worker relationship is missing. Deference to age does not entirely account for this behaviour. Shared histories and family connections explain it better. The forbears of both men are from Burma having come to Madras as repatriates following the 1962 coup. Repatriates Khadija Beevi and her husband started this shop 45 years ago and handed over its reins to their son Shahul. They have made sure their trusted lieute-

A dish's bio data

Here is Atho's biodata. Street food. Born in Burma. Naturalised in Madras. It is a hugely spicy form of noodles paired with shredded vegetables and the spiciness comes from a range of flavourings, which include chilli flakes, garlic, tamarind and fried onion. There is poetry to how it is made: the noodles along with its pairings is tossed by hand.

nant Vincent Alphonse who has worked with them for 30 years, is by their son's side assisting him. When his parents arrived in Madras from Burma in 1965, Alphonse was three years old, and his siblings were also children of tender years. Probably due to the effect of shared histories and family bonds and age, Shahul lets Vincent do the talking. One thing Vincent holds close to his heart is the customers telling him how conspicuous his absence is on the days he is not present in the shop. The cart draws bankers, lawyers, and college students, serving them vegetable, chicken, and fried Atho, alongside mohinga noodles traditionally accompanied by soup and banana stem. Vincent however notes mohinga has never matched Altho's popularity. Vincent says the secret of a good Atho moves far beyond its cooking process; it is in the mixing. Every component must come together correctly for the taste to emerge perfectly. He remarks fried atho is an entirely Indian twist to the Burmese dish. The cart employs around five people for smooth functioning. The sales dip during periods of religious abstinence from non-vegetarian food, but vegetable Atho sufficiently fills the gap and, Vincent says, has the highest demand. Vincent's composed voice could not hide his immense pride as he spoke about how the shop received a Vijay TV award for Best Navu (Meal) in 2012, an honour he credits to their taste. He adds that the shop holds an FSSAI certification, with employees having participated in food safety meetings.

Further down Second Line Beach Road, another Atho stall, called Burma Atho Shop, carries the same sense of a legacy being passed on. Rahamathulla took over the business from his uncle who had learnt the art of making Atho in Burma. And he makes it the way his uncle taught him. However, along the way, he has also tweaked Atho to suit local taste buds. His menu has grown to nearly 10 choices, spanning vegetable and fried Atho, including chicken and egg versions, with customers able to adjust the spice and flavours to their liking. And thereby he enables Burma, Madras and Chennai coexist, defying the limitations of time and geography.

As part of Madras Week, Resilience Series tracks traders and markets that have adapted to changing times and thrived in the city that was once called Madras



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An open well in Besant Nagar.
FILE PHOTO: KARUNAKARAN M

With the right design, an open well need not be a space taker; it can instead offer space for parking or anything else in addition to providing water-related benefits, as these communities in Chennai discovered with the help of The Rain Centre

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

For many apartment residents in Chennai, an open well may sound like something from another time – a structure with a parapet wall, a pulley and a bucket. With space at a premium, keeping one may seem impractical. But an open well does not necessarily mean giving up a parking spot or valuable open space. With the right design, it can be built below ground, allowing vehicles to pass over it while the well continues to collect rainwater and recharge groundwater.

This is what N. Ramshankar, an executive member of The Rain Centre, has done at the Rain Centre in Adyar. An old open well that once had only about two feet of water now holds around 16 feet after rooftop rainwater was direct-

Park your car over your open well

ed into it with minimal filtration.

Sekhar Raghavan, director, The Rain Centre, weighs in about this open well on the premises of the Rain Centre: “Unless I open the lid, you will not even know that there is an open well below.” Such wells can even be incorporated into driveways or parking areas, Sekhar says, provided they are kept away from structural columns. “You can have your open well within your stilt car parking,” says Sekhar. The minimum space required for the well, according to him, is about 3.25 feet in diameter.

“We were afraid in the initial days. We were wondering whether an open well can be closed and whether it will accumulate gas and all that. An engineer told us, ‘Don’t make that mistake, nothing will happen.’ He even set up a vent for us,” says Ramshankar. The parapet wall was subsequently removed and a slab was placed at floor level. “We demolished the parapet wall of the well and then we put a slab on it, at the floor level. Now we have vehicles going on top of it,” he says.

The benefit has not been limited to saving space. The quality of

the water has also improved. “The TDS has also been diluted from almost 850 to now 400,” he says.

For Ramshankar, the value of an open well lies in what it can provide while also being replenished. Open wells generally tap the shallow aquifer, around 25 to 30 feet below the ground and, at most, about 40 feet. Unlike the deeper hard-rock aquifer tapped by borewells, this shallow groundwater can be replenished more easily through rainwater harvesting. Rooftop rainwater can be directed into an existing well, replenishing the water and helping dilute salts and TDS.

Sekhar Raghavan says open wells generally tap the shallow groundwater layer, which can be replenished through rainwater harvesting.

“During monsoon, your open well will have a lot of water, and a couple of months thereafter. So,

We made these collection pits at every gate and diverted the water to the percolation pits.

start tapping it. Then during summer months, go to your borewell,” he says. For an apartment, this can also translate into a reduction in dependence on tanker water.

Keeping the tankers away

At Hiranya Apartments in Raja Annamalaipuram, resident Raghunandan Ranganathan says the open well was never shut, even though three borewells had been installed and two were later closed. “This open well is what is giving us a lot of water,” he says.

The apartment already had rainwater-harvesting infrastructure, including percolation wells. But during heavy rain, water would collect in the compound and flow out through the gates onto the road. The residents then sought Sekhar Raghavan's help.

“We made these collection pits at every gate and diverted the water to the percolation pits, which in turn were feeding the well,” says Raghunandan. Over time, the system changed the quality and availability of water in the apartment.

“Builders often do not make use of the open wells available on

a property. Instead, they tend to shut them down and install borewells. I am not able to understand the logic behind this.”

Making use of the monsoon

At Bayview Apartments in Besant Nagar, the open well has been in use since the apartment was built around 1989-90. “We are using an open well. Generally, during the rain, mainly after the Northeast Monsoon, it fills up,” says resident K. Sangameshwar.

The apartment also has two borewells and a Metro Water connection. During the rainy season, residents use more of the open well and borewell. Rainwater from the terrace is directed towards the ground, with parts of the system leading close to the open well. The complex also has rainwater-harvesting pits in its open areas. “So all these go into the well, and from the well, I think it slowly percolates into the groundwater,” says Sangameshwar.

Unlike the well at The Rain Centre, the Bayview well remains above ground, with a cover and mesh over it. It shows that there is no single way for an apartment to retain an open well. It can remain visible in an open space, or it can be covered and integrated into a driveway or parking area.

For apartment residents, then, the question may not be whether there is enough space for an open well. It could be whether the space already available can be put to better use – above the ground for parking, and below it for water



Teams from Spartan Exclusive School and Government High School in Kumily during the presentation function.

The Government High School in Kumily emerged as the overall champion in the 15th ABC (All a'Bout Cancer) Exhibition 2026, an inter-school cancer awareness initiative.

In the private schools category, Spartan Exclusive School in Mogappair East walked away with the honours.

Organised by CAN-STOP (Cancer Support Therapy to Overcome Pain), an outreach programme of Sundaram Medical Foundation, at Madras Christian College Higher Secondary School in Chetpet, the event drew more than 900 students from 70 schools. The students got to learn about cancer pre-

Making students *ambassadors* of cancer awareness

Spartan Exclusive School in Mogappair East won the overall champion award at the 15th ABC Exhibition 2026

vention, early detection and healthy living.

The initiative encourages students to communicate the message

of cancer awareness through information stalls, painting, skits, quiz, oratorical competitions, and photography, a press release stated.

The schools were awarded a cash prize of ₹25,000 each in recognition of their outstanding performance.

The winners were recognised for their overall performance and active participation across the various competitions and activities conducted as part of the expo.

The expo was inaugurated by J. C. D. Prabhakar, Speaker of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly, in the presence of Dr. Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan, founder of CAN-STOP.

J. C. D. Prabhakar said, "Cancer awareness must begin early, and educating young minds is one of the most effective ways of creating a healthier society. The ABC Exhibition is a commendable initiative

because it provides students not only with knowledge about cancer prevention and early detection but also with the confidence to share that message with their families and communities."

In a release, Vijaya Bharathi Rangarajan said, "The ABC expo was created with the belief that cancer awareness should reach young people in a meaningful and engaging way. Seeing students research, learn, create, and communicate messages about cancer prevention is deeply encouraging. I hope the students become ambassadors of awareness and carry the message of prevention and early detection into their homes and communities."

Televisions with **RGB technology**



Sony launched its latest 'Bravia True RGB Televisions' at an event held at Girias Showroom in Mahalingapuram.

Sony is committed to delivering superior picture quality and an immersive viewing experience through its innovative True RGB technology, said a release.

To celebrate the festive season, the mul-

tinational conglomerate has announced a special promotional offer on its newly launched Bravia True RGB televisions.

Customers can avail attractive cash-back offers, a 1-EMI-free scheme, and a complimentary three-year warranty. The new Bravia True RGB Televisions are now available at Girias showrooms, the release added.

Eye donation competition winners honoured

More than 125 people were honoured with awards and certificates for their efforts to promote awareness on eye donation in the city.

TwinTech Healthcare Services, a unit of TwinTech Institute of Education Trust, organised a statewide essay competition to promote awareness of eye donation on the theme 'Donate Eyes, Gift Sight and Give Life.'

The competition received over 125 en-

tries from students, healthcare professionals and teachers.

The winners were announced on August 25, the first day of National Eye Donation Fortnight 2026 (August 25-September 8).

Kirthika R G, co-ordinator, STEM Lab, Chennai, and one of the winners, said, "The competition gave me an opportunity to reflect on the importance of eye donation and how a single decision can help restore sight and bring hope to others."

Final day of Pothys 'Kolusu Kondattam'

Pothys Swarna Mahal, a leading jewellery retailer, has brought tradition and contemporary style with its 'Kolusu Kondattam' mela, held across its showrooms in the State.

Featuring an impressive collection of over 5,000 designs, the mela offers customers an extensive choice of plain, antique, and designer silver anklets.

Customers can purchase plain silver anklets with no making charges and GST. Customers will pay only for the silver weight and the prevailing silver rate. In addition, antique and fancy designer anklets are available at a 10 percent discount off the max-

imum retail price, said a release.

The showrooms are on GST Road, Chromepet; Ruk-

mani Nagar, Poonamallee; C.T.H. Road, Padi; and in Coimbatore, Salem, Tirunelveli, and Trichy.

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Passengers sang along, clapped and grooved.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Madras Week celebrated on a train ride

When Madras Day arrived, Chennai welcomed it on the move with a musical Metro ride; the celebration was punctuated with a pause to show commuters how to use the Metro with civic sense

At the stroke of midnight, as August 22 turned into Madras Day, 150 Chennaiites boarded a Metro train at Chennai Central for a freshly aligned troika: music, community and Metro awareness. The three-fold experience was jointly organised by Super Chennai and Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) to celebrate the city through moving snapshots of it, as well as appreciate its lifeline, the Metro that gives it movement.

At the Chennai Central Metro station, before the participants embarked on the Metro ride, a cake was cut by the CMRL mascot. On the ride, Chennai-based folk music ensemble Office Gaana took their place across two compartments. Special arrangements ensured that passengers seated

across both compartments could experience the concert. Office Gaana launched into one song after another in their distinctive folk style, turning the Metro into a moving sing-along, says a press release

Passengers sang along, clapped, grooved and, at several points, even moved to the floor of the compartments to get closer to the music. For nearly an hour, the train became a celebration on wheels, travelling from Chennai Central to Arumbakkam and back.

The midnight ride doubled as a Metro awareness initiative, with announcements and messages woven into the musical journey. Participants were reminded about simple but important aspects of using the Metro responsibly – allowing passengers to alight before board-

ing, keeping the coaches clean, following safety guidelines, respecting fellow commuters and making the best use of the Metro system.

J Roddick, one of the participants, travelled all the way from Padur in OMR to be part of the experience.

“The moment they opened registrations, I thought this was going to be one insane experience that I should not miss,” he said.

“Madras Day has grown tremendously over the years, with people from different walks of life coming together to celebrate the city. We wanted to create an experience that reflected the Chennai of today – young, energetic, rooted in its culture, but constantly looking for new experiences,” said Ranjeeth Rathod, MD, Super Chennai.

Musical programme for a cause

Satrangi's next presentation will be held on August 30 from 6 p.m. onwards at Chinmaya Heritage Centre, Harrington Road, Chetpet. This programme will feature memorable songs sung by Indian Idol Top Winner Avirbhav, Anirvinhya, Promod and Smriti supported by a live orchestra.

This programme is in aid of RMD Nursing Training for Girls. Donor passes for this event are priced at ₹5000/ ₹2500/ ₹1200/ ₹800 and will be home delivered on calling 9884778073.



Special trains between Tambaram and Velankanni

The following special trains will be operated to clear the extra rush of passengers during the Annai Velankanni Festival.

Train No. 06037 Tambaram - Velankanni weekly express special will leave Tambaram at 23.50 p.m., on 31st August, and 07th September (Monday), and reach Velankanni at 07.45 a.m. the next day.

In the return direction, Train

No. 06038 Velankanni - Tambaram weekly express special will leave Velankanni at 00.45 a.m. on 02nd, and 09th September (Wednesday), and reach Tambaram at 07.30 a.m. the next day.

The trains will stop at Chengalpattu, Villupuram, Cuddalore Port, Chidambaram, Mayiladuthurai, Thirunallar, Karaikal, Nagore, and Nagapattinam.

Three-day exhibition of Krishna dolls

Krishna Janmashtami celebrations will be held on September 4 from 6 p.m. onwards at Shree Geeta Bhavan, Avvai Shanmugam Salai, Gopalapuram. This is the 36th year of the celebration organised by the Shree Geeta Bhavan Trust, said a release.

Meenakshi Chitharanjan, Bharatanatyam exponent, will inaugurate the three-day Krishnavatar exhibition and distribute prizes to students who have participated in the inter-school competitions.

Special camp by MTC on September 2

The Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) has invited applications from Industrial Training Institute (ITI) students (Mechanic Motor Vehicle, Mechanic Diesel, Electrician, Auto Electrician, Fitter, Turner, Painter, Welder) for a one-year professional acquain-

tance in ITI, with a stipend of ₹ 14,000 per month.

On September 2, MTC will conduct a special camp from 10 a.m. at the Industrial Training Institute, Chromepet, where students can apply for the one-year training program, said a release from the MTC.

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